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A FIELD GUIDE FROM PERSEVERANT DIGITAL · FOR LAW FIRMS

How to Get More Signed Cases Without Buying Shared Leads

Stop paying for leads three other firms also get. Learn where your signed cases really come from, answer every call, and become the firm people and AI assistants name.

THE SHORT ANSWER · 63 WORDS

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Get more signed cases by owning your own demand instead of renting shared leads. Track cost per signed case by source, answer every inquiry within minutes with a person, make your firm the one Google and AI assistants describe accurately, and follow up with people who are not ready yet. Every ad, message and chatbot must stay inside your state's bar advertising rules.

You pay for leads three other firms got the same minute. By the time intake calls back, the person has talked to someone else, and the invoice still comes. You know your total marketing spend. You probably don’t know what one signed case costs from each source.

Meanwhile, prospects describe what happened to ChatGPT and ask who to call. Sometimes it names a competitor.

This guide is a plan for owners and managing partners in personal injury, estate planning, family law, mass torts and criminal defense. Most of it you can start this week. This is not legal advice, so run anything you publish past whoever handles bar compliance at your firm.

Where do your signed cases actually come from today?

Start with cost per signed case by source, because every other decision depends on it. Calls and form fills are not the number. A source that sends 40

leads and two signed cases can cost more than one that sends eight leads and three signed cases.

Pull last quarter's numbers by matter-opened date, one table per practice area.

Source	Spend	Leads	Consults held	Signed cases	Fees	Cost per signed case
Shared or purchased leads						
Google Ads and Local Services Ads						
Google Business Profile and map pack						
Website and AI answers (self-reported)						
Referring attorneys and past clients						
Seminars or events						
Total						

Cost per signed case = (spend + intake staff time) ÷ signed cases

Example numbers, not benchmarks: a vendor charges $4,000 for 50 shared leads. Your intake team spends 25 hours chasing them at $30 an hour, so $750. Two cases sign. That is $2,375 per signed case.

If the source column is mostly "unknown," add a required source field at intake first.

Why do shared leads cost more than the invoice says?

Shared leads cost more than they look because you pay for the race, not the client. Several firms call the same person at once, and your team spends hours

on people who already chose someone.

There's a rules question too. ABA Model Rule 7.2 lets lawyers pay reasonable costs of advertising but not pay for recommendations. How a vendor gets, sells and routes those leads matters. Ask before you renew:

- [ ] Is each lead sold to us only, or to how many other firms?
- [ ] How was the person told their information would be shared?
- [ ] What consent did they give to be called or texted, and can you show it?
- [ ] Does the vendor ever say or imply it is recommending us?
- [ ] Is our fee per lead, or does it depend on a case signing?
- [ ] Can we see the ad or page that produced the lead?
- [ ] Do you credit leads that are wrong numbers or wrong practice areas?
- [ ] Has your arrangement been reviewed under our state's bar rules?

Keep what pays off. Move the rest into demand you own.

What happens when someone calls your firm at 9 p.m.?

For many firms, the biggest leak is not marketing. It's the phone. In a secret-shopper test of 500 UK law firms, 48% could not be reached by phone and only 33% of emailed firms responded (Clio, March 24, 2025). People who just had a crash or an arrest don't wait for Monday.

Across industries, firms that responded to web leads within an hour were nearly seven times as likely to qualify them (Harvard Business Review, March 2011).

Test yourself tonight and write down what happened.

Test	Who answered?	How long until a human?	Next step offered?
Main number, 9 p.m.			
Website form, 9 p.m.			
Google Business Profile message			
Main number, Saturday noon			

Then fix intake:

- [ ] A person, in-house or a trained answering service, picks up every call, nights and weekends included.
- [ ] Form and chat inquiries get a human call or text within minutes during business hours, and first thing the next morning otherwise.
- [ ] The first conversation collects only what you need for a conflict check and a booking.
- [ ] No legal advice and no predicted outcomes on the first call.
- [ ] Every inquiry has a named owner until it is booked, declined or referred out.
- [ ] Follow-up texts ask people not to send details of their situation by text.

If an AI chatbot answers your site, Florida Bar Ethics Opinion 24-1 (January 2024) says it should disclose that it is AI and should not give legal advice (Hinshaw, February 5, 2024). In Texas, HB 2733, effective September 1, 2025, extends barratry law to social media and electronic messages. Keep every text and email tied to an inquiry the person started. Under the TCPA, autodialed or prerecorded marketing texts still need prior express written consent, and since April 11, 2025 a reply like STOP counts as an opt-out, and opt-outs must be honored within 10 business days (Kelley Drye; Burr & Forman). Not legal advice.

Why does ChatGPT recommend the firm down the street?

AI assistants name the firms they can understand and verify. If your site, profile and reviews tell a thin or inconsistent story, they pick someone else. iLawyer Marketing, a legal marketing agency, surveyed 1,110 US adults and found the share using ChatGPT to research attorneys rose from 28.1% in 2025 to 41.9% in 2026, while Google use fell from 86.7% to 71.9% (iLawyer Marketing, 2026).

We call this Search Essence Optimization: people search to understand you, so your content should meet them there.

Test it. Ask ChatGPT, Google’s AI Mode and Gemini the way a scared prospect would:

Prompt	Firms named	Is the process explanation right for your state?	Are you named?
“I was rear-ended and the other driver’s insurer keeps calling me. Who should I talk to in [city]?”			
“How do I choose an estate planning attorney for a blended family in [city]?”			
“What does a divorce lawyer cost in [state], and is a flat fee normal?”			
“My son was arrested last night in [county]. What happens next?”			

Then close the gaps:

- [ ] Write one plain page per question clients ask: process, timeline, what the consultation covers, how fees work.
- [ ] Give each attorney a bio with bar admissions and a link to the state bar profile. Use “focuses on,” not “specializes in,” unless certified.
- [ ] Choose a specific primary category on your Google Business Profile, such as “Personal injury attorney.”
- [ ] Ask for reviews when a matter closes. Never pay for them or offer incentives for positive ones, which the FTC’s 2024 rule bans (Morgan Lewis, August 26, 2024).
- [ ] Make sure your robots.txt does not block OAI-SearchBot. OpenAI says opted-out sites won’t appear in ChatGPT search answers.

Reviews carry weight: 47% of consumers won’t use a business with fewer than 20 reviews (BrightLocal vendor survey, February 11, 2026). When you reply, never confirm the reviewer was a client or discuss their matter.

What offer gets someone to raise their hand?

The offer that works is a next step a worried person can take without committing. It differs by practice area and never promises a result.

Offer	Fits	Keep it clean
Free case review with a named attorney	Personal injury, mass torts	No case value or likely result
“What to do in the first 48 hours after an arrest” checklist	Criminal defense	Practical steps, not case advice
Flat-fee consultation with clear pricing	Family law	State the fee and what it covers
Will and trust review workshop	Estate planning	Educational, no tax promises

Keep ad forms short: name, phone, practice area, and timeline. Case facts come out on a confidential call, never in an ad platform’s form.

Filing rules affect timing. Under Florida Bar rules, most ads must be filed at least 20 days before first use, though websites are exempt. Texas requires filing with the Advertising Review Committee within 10 days of first use. Build that into every campaign calendar. ABA Model Rule 7.1 bars false or misleading communications, and specialist claims need certification. Not legal advice.

Do estate planning seminars still work?

Yes, when they answer a question people already ask, such as “Do you need a trust, or is a will enough?” Promote two to three weeks out, and remind registrants one week, one day and 15 minutes before (ON24, November 26, 2025). Rule 7.3 limits live person-to-person solicitation, so call only attendees who asked for a follow-up. Count signed plans, not seats.

Where do most owners get stuck?

> **Connecting intake to the matter.** Your intake tool knows the source and your practice platform knows the fee. Getting them to agree, without exposing confidential details, usually takes custom field mapping and a review of what each vendor stores.

> **Answering every call the marketing earns.** More visibility means more calls at odd hours. Without a clear owner for each inquiry, the gains leak out through voicemail.

> **Keeping every message reviewable.** Each new ad, text and chatbot script may need review or filing under your state's rules, and tracking versions and approvals usually lands on an attorney with no time.

If you want a second set of eyes on any of these, book a 25-minute exploration call with the short form at the end of this guide.

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Want a second set of eyes on your plan?

Book a free 25-minute exploration call. We will look at your numbers with you, name the first fixes in order, and tell you honestly if we are not the right fit.

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